

## THE ONE I FAILED AND THE ONE I PASSED

# The PM loop, both times

I interviewed at Microsoft twice. The first time I was rejected. The second time I got the offer with no product management experience at all.

Most interview advice comes from people showing you the round they passed. The useful information is in the one I failed, because the reason I failed it had almost nothing to do with ability and everything to do with which version of myself the format was measuring.

Here is both loops, honestly, including the round where the feedback was that I was not good enough.

## 1 The interview I failed

This was 2016 or 2017, near the end of school, for a software engineering role. I was not desperate. I already had close to ten offers, from Intel, Northrop Grumman, Eli Lilly, IBM, JPL and others. Microsoft would have been a bonus.

I walked in expecting behavioral questions, which were my strength after a lot of practice. I got none. It was one programming question after another. The one I still remember is being asked to write the binary search tree of the word computer.

The problem was not hard. I simply did not enjoy coding and had never made it my strength. My degree was computer engineering and I had leaned hardware: VHDL, VLSI, circuits. On the software side I knew data structures and Big O as concepts without loving them, and solving them live was not natural to me.

I did not do a good job, and I did not get the job.

### EXAMPLE

Before an interview, find out what the format actually measures. Ask the recruiter directly what each round is. I walked into a coding gauntlet prepared for a conversation.

**WHY THIS MATTERS:** I was rejected for being weak at the one thing that loop was built to test, while being strong at things it never asked about. That is not a verdict on you, it is a mismatch, and knowing the difference is what lets you try again.

## 2 The structural problem nobody warns you about

Here is something I wish someone had told me at graduation.

If you get a computer engineering degree, you come out a jack of all trades and a master of none. I did software and I did hardware. Almost every company only hired for one, so every interview swung hard to one side and my experience in the other side counted for nothing.

I tried to sell the combination as an advantage and the market of that moment would not pay for it. Today the industry has moved, and the companies doing best are the ones who own both the hardware and the software.

**EXAMPLE**

If your background spans two things, do not average them into a vague middle. Pick the room where the combination is the point, and be specific about the half that is unusual there.

**WHY THIS MATTERS:** the same profile that got me rejected as an engineer is exactly what got me hired as a PM. Nothing about me changed. The room changed.

### 3 The loop I passed, and its shape

Five interviews, forty to sixty minutes each, four to five hours in a day.

It was not the standard loop people describe. Interviewers flew in, candidates were placed in separate rooms, and the interviewers rotated between rooms. I met senior engineers and senior PMs.

**EXAMPLE**

Ask how many rounds, how long, and who you are meeting. It is a normal question and the answer changes how you pace yourself. Four hours is an endurance event, not a conversation.

**WHY THIS MATTERS:** the last round is where people fall apart, and the last round is the one you can prepare for by simply knowing it is coming.

### 4 Round type one, behavioral

Why do you want to be at Microsoft. Tell me about yourself. Why should we hire you.

These sound like warmups. They are not. They are the rounds where the interviewer decides what story they are going to tell about you afterwards, and everything technical gets filed under that story.

The question I got most often in this category was why I wanted to move from engineering to product. Close to what I actually said:

Engineering is great. You solve problems on the ground and you focus on why things work. But I wanted more of the what and the how. Why are we doing this, who are we doing it for, why does the customer care, what is the dollar value attached. As an engineer your scope is set by what your manager tells you, and you never see how it affects everything upstream.

**EXAMPLE**

Write your reason for the switch in that shape: what the current role gives you, what it does not, and what you want to see instead. Not what is wrong with it. What you can see from it and cannot reach.

**WHY THIS MATTERS:** complaining about your current role is the most common way this answer fails, and it is entirely avoidable.

## 5 Round type two, the case

Mine was how would you design an elevator for blind people.

The instinct is to start designing. Buttons, braille, audio. Every one of those is a guess, and confident guessing is the failure mode this question exists to detect.

Do not solve. Ask.

Who is this for, specifically. Where is the building, what kind, how many floors. What do they do today and where does it fail. What are we optimizing for, safety, speed, independence, cost. Are we retrofitting or building new.

The questions build the context, and the context is what makes an answer an answer instead of a guess. Once you have it, you can name who you are solving for and what problem you are solving, and only then does a design mean anything.

### EXAMPLE

Practise on any object in the room. Design a better kettle. Force yourself to ask five questions before proposing one thing. Five is more than feels natural, which is the point.

**WHY THIS MATTERS:** anybody can become a PM if they put their heart into it. A lot of this is common sense applied in the right order. The order is the skill.

## 6 Round type three, the one you cannot fake

Coding. Write a Sudoku game from scratch.

This was my weakest area and I knew it walking in. I did get to an end to end program, with help, and the feedback afterwards was that my coding was raw.

I thought that was the end of it.

The offer came about a week later.

### EXAMPLE

Identify your one weak round in advance and prepare it to a floor, not a ceiling. The goal is not to be good at it. The goal is to not be disqualifying at it, and to be visibly willing to work through it in front of someone.

**WHY THIS MATTERS:** I was measurably the weakest in one round out of five and still got hired, because the other four said something that round could not. One bad round is survivable. Being unmemorable in all five is not.

## 7 What I actually used to prepare

The book Cracking the PM Interview, by Gayle Laakmann McDowell and Jackie Bavaro. YouTube videos of people working through case studies out loud.

That is the whole list. I did not take a course or pay a coach.

**EXAMPLE**

Watch three case walkthroughs and pause before each answer to give your own first. Watching without answering is entertainment.

**WHY THIS MATTERS:** the volume of paid preparation material aimed at this audience is enormous, and I got in with one book and free videos.

**8 What I wore, since people ask**

I always overdress. Blazer, turtleneck, suit trousers. Some people showed up casual. I would rather carry myself the way I feel best, because it changes how I walk in.

**EXAMPLE**

Wear the thing that makes you feel most like yourself at your most capable. That is a real variable, not a superficial one.

**WHY THIS MATTERS:** the first thirty seconds are decided before you speak, and the only part of that you control is how you arrive.

I failed the first one. I was told I was raw in the second one and got the offer anyway.

The gap between those two was not skill. It was standing in a room built to measure what I actually was, and being able to explain myself when I got there.